

Q What help is available during the early weeks if I feel that I am beginning to struggle?

Taking care of a newborn can be chaotic, tiring, and sometimes overwhelming. Depending on your personal circumstances, you may want some extra, paid help when you return home from the hospital.

There are various options available and it is important to remember that paid child care is generally not cheap. Speak to other mothers for recommendations of good nanny agencies. Magazines and newspapers are also a good source of child-care advertisements. With all forms of child care, it is vital to follow up all the references.



Maternity nurse She will help you take care of your baby in the early weeks. These are generally the most expensive form of child care since they usually live in and cover 24 hours a day, six days a week. Most people employ a maternity nurse for about six weeks. Their role is to help with daytime care as well as taking care of your baby at night, bringing them to you to be fed, and settling them down afterward.



Night nurse If you need help with nighttime duties, this can be a good option. However, the difference between this kind of help and that of a maternity nurse is that they go home during the day and simply come to help with feeding and settling your baby at night. Night nurses can be useful if your partner cannot share the night feedings. Some people choose to have them a couple of nights a week.



Doula This is an experienced woman who offers practical and emotional (nonmedical) support to a mother during and/or after childbirth. Employing a doula as a caregiver has become popular. The time they spend with you is flexible and can range from a few visits at the beginning to fixed hours for a period of eight weeks. They provide breast-feeding support, help around the house, and let you catch up on a few hours of much-needed sleep.

Q How should I plan for my baby's first trip outside?

Getting out of the house with a young baby can be nerve racking and challenging. However,

with a little preparation and planning you'll be able to make your first trip easier and more enjoyable. The first thing to remember is that you'll need to be able to transport your baby reliably and safely when you are out. If you are going by car, you are legally obligated to have an age-appropriate car seat. Think about whether it would be easier to have your baby in a front pack or stroller. If you are using public transportation, it might be a good idea to find out if there are stairs to negotiate. If you are

driving, plan the route, allowing for more stops for feeding and changing your baby. For a first trip outside, try not to be too ambitious. You will still be recovering from the birth so will need to take care of yourself as well as your baby. Whether you are going for a longer drive or walking to local stores, preparation is key.

A diaper bag is vital for any trip outside and should contain the following items:

- » diapers
- » wipes
- » burp cloths
- » change of baby clothes
- » sunscreen (in the summer)
- » spare clothing for yourself in case your baby regurgitates a lot on you.
- » a sanitized bottle and formula if your baby is bottle-fed. (See also p.281).

immunization program that your baby will follow into childhood.

The six-week checkup monitors your baby's progress. The doctor will examine her hips to make sure they are still positioned correctly; listen for any heart irregularities such as a heart murmur; check the alignment of her spine and that there is no dimple at its base that could indicate a nerve problem. For boys, the opening of the penis and the position of the testes will be checked, and for girls, the vaginal area.

Although these things will have already been checked at birth, they are sometimes not detectable until your baby is a bit older. For example, at this point your baby's eyes can be examined to see if she can focus on and follow a moving object. You will be asked whether your baby is smiling and socializing well, and making gurgling and cooing noises as expected. If there are any problems you will be referred to a specialist.

Out and about
Think ahead to what you might need for your baby to help make trips run smoothly.



Q Why do I have to take my baby to see the doctor at six weeks?

Your baby's checkup at six weeks old (though it can be up to eight weeks) is an opportune moment to check that everything is on track. This is done at your doctor's office, and you will also be given a postpartum checkup at this time (see p.259). You may have specific questions about your baby's care, feeding, and sleep patterns, or want to discuss any concerns you have. You can also learn about the



Did you know...

Many hospitals in the US make it easy for you to register your baby for her very own Social Security number. They'll provide you with the paperwork when they give you the forms to file for her birth certificate.